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EDITION 2027

The Whole Algarve

The honest guide to visiting and living here

by Algarve Newsletter

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Checked in September and October 2026.

Corrections: algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/changelog

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BEFORE YOU START

How to use this guide

Who writes it and what it doesn't sell, how it was made, what the marks mean, and what to do when you find a mistake.

I was born in Portimão and brought up here, and thirty years on I
still live here.

That is where this guide starts, and it is also its limit. Nobody knows sixteen municipalities the way they know their own town, and I don't pretend to. So this guide was not written from memory. It was put together from sources you can check, and where a source was silent, the page says so.

These pages say who is behind it, how it was made and how to read it. If you read only one part, read “What the marks mean”.

In this chapter	Who writes · how it was made · how it is organised · what the marks mean · words and conventions · mistakes and updates
The guide	The Whole Algarve · Edition 2027 · by Algarve Newsletter
Covers	All 16 municipalities of the Algarve, and the twelve months
Checked	September and October 2026; each chapter gives its own month at the foot
Paid for by	The people who buy it. No sponsors, no affiliate links
Corrections	algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/changelog
Found a mistake?	algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/report · hello@algarvenewsletter.pt

Who writes this T R P

The guide is published by Algarve Newsletter, a free email in English about the Algarve that goes out on Mondays and Fridays. It is written from Portimão, by someone born and brought up there.

- **What this guide doesn't sell.** Nobody paid to be in it. It has no sponsors and no affiliate links: nothing you book, buy or visit because of these pages earns us anything, unless you go on to one of our own two sites, which the next point describes. We accepted no free meals, rooms or tickets.

- **What our other work does sell**, so that you can weigh it. The newsletter is paid for by local sponsors, who are named as such, and its website carries affiliate links to a tour-booking site. Our events site, Algarve Atlas, has a paid tier. Chapter 41 lists both among its resources and says they are ours.
- **“I” and “we”**. The box that opens each chapter is one person talking. The day it proposes is put together from the chapter’s own sources, like everything else: outside Portimão it is a plan, not a memory. The rest mostly says “we”, because it is the work of the sources as much as of the writer.

How it was made T R P

Each chapter was built from public sources: the town halls, the state’s own pages, the regional and national press, published guides, timetables and price lists. Then every chapter was read a second time against those sources, line by line, and corrected.

- **We have not been to every place in it**. No verdict here claims a visit. The next section says what a verdict is made of.
- **Nothing is invented**. A price, a time, a rule or a date is here because a source gave it, and many carry the month in which we read them.
- **Where we couldn’t find out, we say so**. Each chapter ends with a box called “The honest bit”, which lists what that chapter doesn’t know.
- **Festivals and fairs**. If the 2027 date had been announced when we checked, we give it. If not, we say so and give the 2026 date. The one exception is Easter and the feasts that move with it, whose 2027 dates come from the church calendar. Otherwise we never work out a future date from a past one.
- **Photographs** are real, of the place named, and either under a free licence or in the public domain. The photographer and the licence are beside each one. None is ours.
- **Maps** are drawn for this guide from OpenStreetMap and the state’s boundary data, both credited in Chapter 41.

How it is organised T R P

Start with Chapter 1 if you don't know the Algarve, and with the chapter of your own town if you do.

PART	CHAPTERS	WHAT IS IN IT
I • Orientation	1 to 4	The region in twenty minutes, when to come, where to stay, how many days
II • Logistics without surprises	5 to 8	Getting here, hiring a car, doing without one, money and safety
III • The sixteen municipalities	9 to 24	One chapter each, from Aljezur in the west to Alcoutim in the east
IV • Themes in depth	25 to 31	Beaches, the outdoors, eating, culture, the calendar, families, the honest Algarve
V • Living in the Algarve	32 to 39	Paperwork, home, health, cars, money and tax, everyday life, fitting in, the resident's year
VI • Tools	40 to 42	Phrases and glossaries, maps and resources, the indexes

- **Three kinds of reader.** Beside most section titles there is a mark: T for visitors, R for people from abroad who live here, P for Portuguese readers. A section with one mark was written for that reader; the others can skip it.
- **Every municipality chapter has the same order:** towns and villages, beaches (the nearest ones, where there is no coast), eating, markets, festivals, nature, heritage, living there, and where to stay. Faro and Tavira add a section on boats.
- **The verdicts are given in the municipality chapters.** The chapters of Parts I and IV gather what those say and send you to the page; they add no verdicts of their own.

What the marks mean T R P

A verdict answers the question you would ask a friend: is it worth going? There are no stars and no scores out of five.

MARK	NAME	WHAT IT MEANS
◆◆◆ Worth the trip	Worth the trip	Plan a day around it. At most three in a municipality
◆◆ Worth a detour	Worth a detour	Go if you are within half an hour
◆ If you're nearby	If you're nearby	Pleasant, but don't cross the Algarve for it
✕ Skip it	Skip it	Not worth your time or money. The reason is always given

- **A verdict is a judgement made from evidence**, and not the report of a visit. We weighed what published guides and the national and regional press say of a place, and what thousands of visitors wrote about it, against four questions: is there anything like it nearby, how good is it, what does it cost in time and money, and does it serve the people who live here.
- **No verdict without two independent sources**. A place with fewer is described and left unmarked. Pharmacies, public offices and bus stops are unmarked: they are here to be useful, not to be judged.
- **The top mark needs more**: a strong published source as well, and no more than three places in a municipality may hold it.
- **We print no ratings**, ours or anyone else's. We read what visitors wrote on Tripadvisor and Google, but a number out of five doesn't answer the question. Where a chapter says how a place is reviewed, it says it in words, or counts the low scores among the latest reviews and names the platform.
- **The verdict belongs to the place, not the month**. Where the season changes it, the text says so.

The tags

TAG	NAME	WHEN IT IS GIVEN
▼ Locals' pick	Locals' pick	Many of its reviews are in Portuguese, or the local press writes about it, or our events site lists it as a local find
⌘ Good off-season	Good off-season	Worth going between November and March. Where the place keeps hours, it is open all year and we confirmed them
↑ Rainy-day option	Rainy-day option	Indoors, or worth it in bad weather
■ Easy with kids	Easy with kids	Access, toilets, safety, and enough to hold a child's attention
↔ No car needed	No car needed	Reached by bus, train, boat or on foot from the main town of a municipality

Prices

For a restaurant, the band is one person's main course and a drink, without a bottle of wine, at 2026 prices.

BAND	PER PERSON
€	Up to €15
€€	€15 to €30
€€€	€30 to €50
€€€€	More than €50

Words and conventions T R P

- **Places keep their Portuguese names**, with the accents: Loulé, Olhão, São Brás de Alportel. Chapter 40 says how to pronounce them.
- **A municipality** is a *concelho*: a town and the country around it, run by a town hall, the *Câmara Municipal*. The Algarve has sixteen. Each is divided into parishes, *freguesias*, each with its own small council, the *Junta*.
- **Barlavento and Sotavento** are the western and eastern halves of the Algarve. **The barrocal** is the limestone country behind the coast, and **the serra** is the hills behind that. Chapter 1 explains all four.
- **Prices are in euros and are those of 2026**, with the month we read them where it matters. Expect them to have risen.
- **Opening hours change with the season**, and some places close for part of the winter. Where a source gave winter hours we print them; where it didn't, ring before a long drive.
- **Driving times** come from Google Maps or, in a few places that say so, from a route planner. Take them as a guide.
- **Web addresses are printed without "https://"**. If one doesn't open, put "www." in front of it (Chapter 41).
- **"Last checked"** at the foot of each chapter is the month in which that chapter's facts were last read against their sources.

Mistakes and updates T R P

Some of what is printed here will be wrong by the time you read it. A restaurant closes, a bus line changes, a fee goes up.

- **Corrections** to this edition are listed at algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/changelog, with the chapter and the date. They are free to read throughout 2027.
- **If you find a mistake**, tell us at algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/report, or write to hello@algarvenewsletter.pt. Say which chapter and section, and where you read the right answer if you can. We check it before we change anything.

- **If you live here and think a verdict is wrong**, say that too, and why. The best of those letters will shape the next edition.
- **The next edition.** The guide is dated because it is meant to be redone each year. We have not yet decided how the 2028 edition will be offered to people who bought this one.

The honest bit

- **This is one person's guide and many sources' work.** The writer knows Portimão from the inside and the other fifteen municipalities as a neighbour does.
- **A verdict is not a visit.** It is as good as the sources behind it, and where they were thin there is no verdict.
- **Checking twice doesn't make a page right for ever.** Everything here was true to its source in September or October 2026.
- **We have interests of our own:** a newsletter with sponsors and an events site with a paid tier. Nobody who pays either of them gets a verdict for it. One tag, Locals' pick, can rest on our events site's own list of local finds, as the table of tags says.
- **There is no online map and no track file** with this edition. Chapter 41 says where each trail publishes its own.

LAST CHECKED: OCTOBER 2026 · CORRECTIONS:
ALGARVENEWSLETTER.PT/GUIDE/CHANGELOG



Photo: Summerbrize, CC BY-SA 4.0

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PART III · ZONE B · CENTRAL BARLAVENTO AND THE SERRA DE MONCHIQUE

Portimão

A river port with a museum in a sardine cannery, the big sands of Praia da Rocha and Alvor, a lagoon behind the dunes and a racing circuit in the hills.

If you were here with me, we'd be at the door of the museum in the old sardine cannery when it opens at ten, and afterwards we'd walk up the quay to the old iron bridge and eat sardines off the charcoal at lunch, because that is when the best grill is open. In the afternoon we'd drive ten minutes to Alvor, wait for low tide and walk the boardwalk over the dunes to the rock arches of Três Irmãos. You could have Praia da Rocha the next day, for the sand and the swim.

Portimão is the third-largest municipality in the Algarve by population and by tourism: its hotels and larger rentals sold 2.8 million nights in 2025, more than one in eight of the region's. It is a working city on a river, with the full-service hospital of the western Algarve, a resort of apartment towers on the cliff where the river meets the sea, a low-rise village on a lagoon and a hilly, almost empty north.

Best for	A wide beach with everything at hand; the cannery museum and a sardine lunch; Alvor as a family base; boat trips to the caves and up the river to Silves; motor racing; a city that works all year
Skip if	You want a pretty old town or a quiet village. The resort at Praia da Rocha is a line of tower blocks, and the city is plain once you leave the river
Capital of	Grilled sardines and the canning past; the Algarve's biggest beach resort
From Faro airport	49 min by car to Portimão, Alvor or Mexilhoeira Grande, 56 min to Praia da Rocha · the airport bus takes about 1 h 30 to Portimão's bus terminal · trains from Faro take 1 h 12 to 1 h 30
From Portimão	Hospital 8 min · Praia do Vau 9 min · Praia da Rocha 10 min · Alvor 13 min · Mexilhoeira Grande 17 min · Alcalar 17 min · Lagoa 18 min · Silves 23 min · the racing circuit 23 min · Lagos 33 min · Monchique 35 min · Albufeira 37 min
Beaches	About 8 km of coast; eight official bathing waters, all lifeguarded from 1 June to 30 September; six Blue Flags in 2026
Best months	May, June, September and October. In 2026 the sardine season opened in May. In July and August the sands at Praia da Rocha and Vau are packed. In winter the city, the museum and the walks carry on, and Alvor runs at half strength from January to Easter
Population	59,845 (Census 2021), about 78,100 by the end of 2025 (INE estimate) · three parishes · 182 km ²
Don't miss	The Museu de Portimão · sardines at lunch by the old bridge · the Alvor boardwalk to Três Irmãos at low tide



The places in this chapter, numbered as in the text. Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL) · boundaries CAOP 2025 © DGT

Towns and villages T R P

The municipality has three parishes, unchanged by the reforms of 2013 and 2025. Portimão parish holds the city, Praia da Rocha and four in five of the residents. Alvor is the village on the lagoon, with its beaches, the aerodrome and the Penina

golf hotel. Mexilhoeira Grande is half the municipality's area and has 47 people to the square kilometre. About 23,100 foreign residents held permits here at the end of 2025, the third-largest number in the Algarve after Loulé and Albufeira.

1 • Portimão

◆◆ Worth a detour

↑ Rainy-day option

⌘ Good off-season

⇒ No car needed

The city stands on the west bank of the Arade, 2 to 3 km up the estuary from the sea. It grew as a port for dried fruit and then for canned fish, and was rebuilt for tourism from the 1960s. Lonely Planet calls it rough around the edges, a place most visitors only pass through on the way to the beach, and in the same breath praises its long waterfront and its museum. Residents who answer on Tripadvisor's forum say the same two things: the riverside and the old streets behind it are pleasant, and away from the river it is high-rise. Give it half a day.



The quay at Portimão, with the old road bridge on the right. Photo: Vitor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0



The canning hall of the Museu de Portimão in 2021. Photo: Vitor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0

- **Museu de Portimão**

◆◆◆ Worth the trip

↑ Rainy-day option

⌘ Good off-season

⇒ No car needed

: the municipal museum, opened in 2008 in the Feu Hermanos sardine cannery on the quay, which worked from about 1902 to the 1980s. The Council of Europe gave it its Museum Prize for 2010. Lonely Planet ranks it twelfth among the best things to do in the Algarve.

- **What you see:** the room where the fish were headed, with its conveyor and tables, the canning line and a film that several visitors say makes the visit. The first rooms cover the prehistoric tombs of Alcalar, the Romans and the river. Allow an hour to an hour and a half. Of the twenty latest reviews, one complained that many labels are in Portuguese only and two of a curt reception.
- **Hours and prices:** from September to July, Tuesday 14:30 to 18:00 and Wednesday to Sunday 10:00 to 18:00. In August it opens in the evening instead: Tuesday 19:00 to 23:00, Wednesday to Sunday 14:00 to 23:00. Closed Mondays and public holidays. €3, or €4 with Alcalar; €1.50 for over-65s and ages 16 to 25; free on Sundays for residents of Portugal. Rua D. Carlos I. Phone 282 405 230.
- **The riverside** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇄ **No car needed** : a level walk of about 1 km from the old bridge to the museum. It starts at the Largo da Barca, where a ferry crossed before the bridge was built and the grilled-fish houses now stand, and passes the Jardim Visconde Bivar of 1905, the Praça Manuel Teixeira Gomes and the old fish-auction building, which houses the tourist office. A crane of 1948 still stands on the quay.
- **Largo 1.º de Dezembro** ♦ **If you're nearby** : a small garden of 1931 whose benches are faced with tile panels, designed in 1930, showing ten scenes of Portuguese history from the founding of the nation to the Republic. The 18th-century palace behind it is the municipal theatre, TEMPO.
- **Igreja Matriz** ♦ **If you're nearby** : on the high ground of the old town. The earthquake of 1755 left the late-Gothic doorway, carved by masons who had worked on Silves cathedral, and the Manueline holy-water stoups; the rest was rebuilt. Storks nest on the roof. The tourism board lists it as open on weekdays from 10:00 to 12:30 and 15:00 to 19:00; phone 282 422 612 to be sure.
- **Colégio dos Jesuítas** ♦ **If you're nearby** : the Jesuit college and church that fill one side of the Alameda, the main square. Built from 1660 and consecrated in 1707, with a single very high nave. The national heritage register calls it the largest church in the Algarve. Listed as open on weekdays, 08:00 to 12:30 and 15:00 to 18:00.

- **Casa Manuel Teixeira Gomes** ♦ If you're nearby ⬆️ Rainy-day option : the house where the writer was born who became President of the Republic in 1923. Two exhibition rooms and part of his library; one reviewer found the panels in Portuguese only. Tuesday to Friday, 10:00 to 12:30 and 14:00 to 17:00; Saturday afternoon. Free. Rua Júdice Biker 1.
- **The market** ♦ If you're nearby ⬆️ Rainy-day option : a modern hall of 2007 on Avenida São João de Deus, about 450 m west of the Alameda, with a separate fish hall. A working market, and a good one for anyone with a kitchen. See *Markets and fairs*.
- **The town walls:** fragments between houses. Nothing is signposted.
- **From the quay:** boats leave for the sea caves, up the river to Silves and across to Ferragudo. See *Nature and walks*.
- **Tourist office:** in the old fish-auction building on the riverside. Phone 282 242 620. We found no opening hours.
- **Parking:** the underground car park under the Alameda has 226 spaces, at €2 for the first hour and €16.50 for a day; the one by the town hall charges €2.20 an hour. Street parking on the quay at Largo do Dique is charged on working days in April, May and October, and every day until midnight from June to September.
- **Time needed:** half a day with the museum and lunch.
- **Getting there:** 49 min by car from Faro airport. The railway station is 800 m north of the riverside gardens. Regional buses stop on the riverside in Avenida Guanaré; coaches and the airport bus use the bus terminal beside the station, 1.4 km to the north. Town bus 30 joins the terminal, the station and the quay every half hour on working days, and bus 37 about hourly at weekends.
- **Last checked:** October 2026

2 · Praia da Rocha

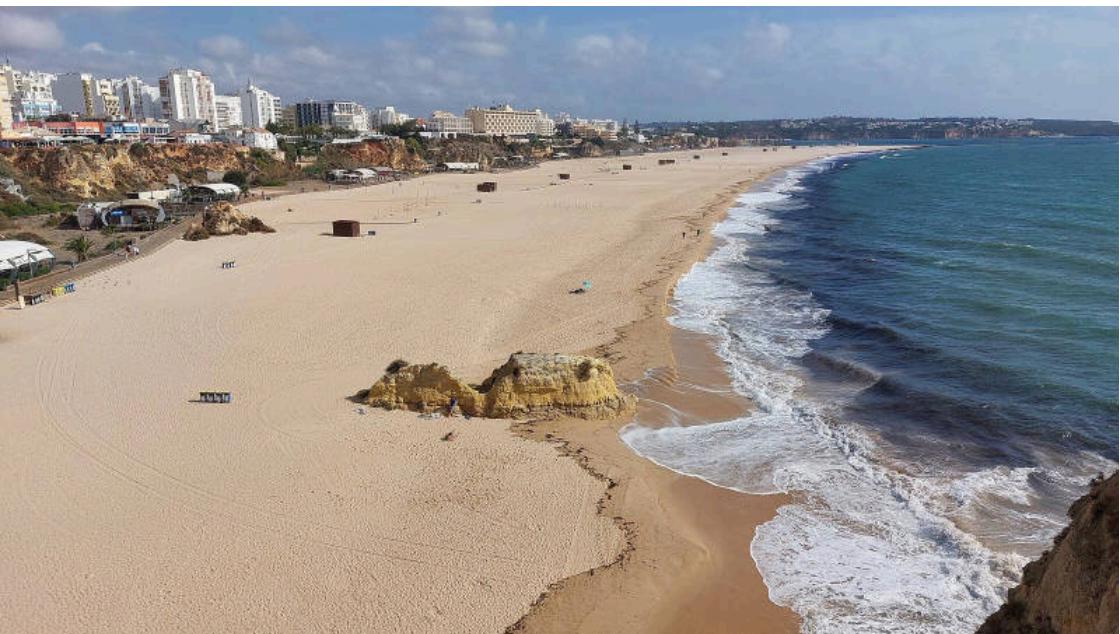
♦ If you're nearby

■ Easy with kids

↔ No car needed

The seaside quarter of the city: one avenue, 1.2 km long, on the cliff top above a very wide beach, with a fort at one end and a viewpoint at the other. A casino opened here in 1910, a grand hotel in 1932, and from the 1970s the cliff-top chalets gave way to apartment towers. Rough Guides ranks the beach sixth in the Algarve and describes the resort as louder and less refined, with buildings that will win no design awards.

Come for the day. Across four threads on Tripadvisor's forums between 2019 and 2026, eight regulars advised against staying here and two were for it. The ones against call it a concrete resort and send people to Alvor, Lagos or Carvoeiro to sleep; several of them add that the beach is lovely.



Praia da Rocha from the Três Castelos viewpoint in November 2025, looking east. Photo: 5R-MFT, CC BY-SA 4.0

- **The beach** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** 🏠 Easy with kids 🚗 No car needed : more than 1 km of sand, lifeguarded, with a Blue Flag, a wooden promenade along its whole length and cafés on it. Lonely Planet names it among the best sheltered, shallow beaches for babies and toddlers. Rough Guides sends families to the end by the fort; one reviewer found the middle the quietest part in high season.
- **Getting down:** the avenue is on the cliff and the sand is below, by staircases. The level way in is at the east end, from the marina. A visitor on a three-week stay never found a step-free access from the avenue.

- Fortaleza de Santa Catarina** ♦ If you're nearby ✱ Good off-season ⇌ No car needed : a fort of the 1630s at the east end of the avenue, built to a design of 1621 to close the river mouth with the fort at Ferragudo opposite. Inside are a small chapel faced with blue tiles and a terrace that looks over the marina, the river mouth and the beach. It is a free viewpoint, with little else to see. Structural repairs ended in June 2026. The staircase from the fort down to the marina was closed in November 2025, and we could not confirm that it has reopened.
- Miradouro dos Três Castelos** ♦♦ Worth a detour ✱ Good off-season ⇌ No car needed : the viewpoint at the west end of the avenue, named for three sea stacks. The place for sunset.
- Praia dos Três Castelos** ♦♦ Worth a detour : the next beach west, below the viewpoint, with stacks, arches and a Blue Flag. It is reached by a long staircase, or along the sand from Praia da Rocha at low tide. A sign warns against sitting under the cliff.
- The marina** ♦ If you're nearby 🏠 Easy with kids : 620 berths at the river mouth, opened in 2000, with a small beach beside it inside the breakwater. Praia da Marina has calm water, level access, lifeguards and a Blue Flag. Many of the cave boats leave from the marina.
- Praia dos Careanos** ♦ If you're nearby : a cove between Três Castelos and Vau, down a steep staircase. It is the one beach here officially classed as of limited use, because the access itself is within reach of falling rock, and the cliff top above it was fenced off after the storms of early 2026.
- The avenue at night:** bars, clubs and a casino in the Hotel Algarve. You will know whether it is for you. A resident on the forum describes the strip as mainly cheap Irish bars, with better places away from the strip and at the marina end.
- Festivals on the sand:** Afro Nation fills the beach for three days at the turn of June and July (3 to 5 July in 2026), with 35,000 to 40,000 people a day. A reviewer in June 2026 described the stages being built at night. If you want a quiet beach, avoid those two weeks.
- Works on the sand:** see *The honest bit*. Expect pipes, machines and closed stretches between here and Vau in the winter of 2026–27.

END OF THE FREE SAMPLE

The Portimão chapter goes on for 25 more pages.

Its beaches one by one, where to eat and what to skip, the markets, the festivals of the year, and what it is like to live there.

Then there are fifteen more municipalities, and the rest of the 1,535 pages of the guide.

algarvenewsletter.pt/guide